

to get on his operational flank by moving to the west. To foil him, Hooker proposed to Lincoln a rapid descent on Richmond. The Confederates, he considered, would be forced to retreat to protect their capital.

“I think Lee’s army, and not Richmond, is your true objective point,” Lincoln responded curtly. He added that the Confederates had to be spread out as they headed west and north, and urged Hooker to attack and defeat the enemy posthaste, declaring: “The animal must be very slim somewhere. Could you not break him?”

The general chose to disobey Lincoln, however, and instead of attacking, he trailed Lee’s advance cautiously, while keeping between the Confederates and Washington. As he did so, Confederate general Richard Stoddert Ewell’s corps successfully attacked and destroyed the Union garrison at Winchester on June 13–15. During this raid, Ewell was able to capture many thousands of prisoners, artillery, horses, and supplies in a masterly manner, reminiscent of Stonewall Jackson’s seizure of Harpers Ferry the year before. Hooker resigned on June 28, 1863, following continued arguments with Lincoln.

The road to Gettysburg

Union attempts to determine the whereabouts of the Confederate army met with repeated failure. The president despaired as the telegraph wires grew increasingly hot with frantic appeals from Pennsylvania governor, Andrew Curtin, who reported that the Confederates had entered his state and were threatening the Pennsylvania capital, Harrisburg. Where was the Army of the Potomac?

Lincoln’s patience was wearing thin, citizens in Pennsylvania’s border counties girded themselves for occupation by the Confederates, and the North held its collective breath as all eyes turned to south-central Pennsylvania.